

Self Efficacy

Positive psychology is a concept introduced by psychologist **Albert Bandura**.

“It refers to an individual's belief in their ability to successfully execute specific actions or behaviors to achieve desired outcomes.”

“Self-efficacy is the confidence a person has in their own capabilities to accomplish tasks, overcome challenges, and achieve goals.”

When people have high self-efficacy, they tend to:

Set challenging goals: They are more likely to set ambitious and meaningful goals because they believe they have the ability to achieve them.

Persist in the face of obstacles: Individuals with high self-efficacy are more likely to persevere and put in the effort necessary to overcome difficulties or setbacks.

Have a positive outlook: People with strong self-efficacy beliefs are more optimistic about their abilities, which can lead to higher levels of motivation and a more positive mindset.

Cope effectively with stress: High self-efficacy is associated with better stress management and resilience, as individuals believe they can handle stressful situations.

Learn and grow: Those with high self-efficacy are more likely to seek out opportunities for learning and development, as they have confidence in their ability to acquire new skills and knowledge.

Developmental antecedents

Mastery Experiences: When individuals experience repeated successes in a particular area, they develop a stronger belief in their ability to perform well in similar situations.

Vicarious Learning: Observing others succeed or fail in tasks similar to those one faces can also impact self-efficacy. If people see someone similar to themselves succeeding, it can boost their own belief in their capabilities.

Social Persuasion: Encouragement, feedback, and support from others can significantly influence self-efficacy. Positive and constructive feedback can enhance an individual's belief in their abilities, while negative feedback can have the opposite effect.

Emotional and Physiological States: High levels of anxiety can lower self-efficacy, while positive emotional experiences can enhance it. Similarly, physiological factors like fatigue or illness can influence a person's confidence in their abilities.

Cognitive Appraisal: How individuals interpret their own thoughts and feelings in response to situations can impact self-efficacy. Positive self-talk and constructive cognitive appraisal can bolster self-efficacy, while negative self-talk and pessimistic interpretations can undermine it.

Cultural and Social Context: Cultural norms, societal expectations, and the influence of significant others (parents, teachers, peers) can all shape an individual's self-efficacy beliefs. Cultural factors can influence what activities or skills are valued and emphasized, affecting a person's sense of competence in those areas.

Early Childhood Experiences: Early experiences, including parenting styles, early educational experiences, and the level of support and encouragement received during childhood, can have lasting effects on the development of self-efficacy.

Neurobiology of self-efficacy

Prefrontal Cortex (PFC): The prefrontal cortex, particularly the dorsolateral prefrontal cortex (DLPFC), is essential for higher-order cognitive processes, including executive functions like planning, decision-making, and problem-solving. Self-efficacy is closely tied to cognitive processes, and the PFC plays a crucial role in evaluating one's abilities and planning actions to achieve goals.

Striatum: The striatum is a brain region involved in reward processing and reinforcement learning. When individuals experience success or achievement, it activates the brain's reward system, reinforcing self-efficacy beliefs. This positive reinforcement can lead to increased confidence and motivation to tackle similar tasks in the future.

Amygdala: The amygdala is associated with emotional processing, particularly fear and anxiety. Self-efficacy beliefs can influence how individuals perceive and respond to challenges and threats. When facing challenging situations, individuals with higher self-efficacy may have reduced amygdala activation and, consequently, experience less fear and anxiety.

Hippocampus: The hippocampus is critical for learning and memory. Successful experiences and mastery of tasks, which are central to building self-efficacy, are stored as memories in the hippocampus. These memories can be retrieved in future situations to boost confidence and problem-solving skills.

Dopamine: Dopamine is a neurotransmitter associated with motivation, reward, and reinforcement. It plays a role in the brain's reward system, linking successful experiences to positive emotions. Dopamine release in response to achievements can strengthen self-efficacy beliefs and encourage individuals to pursue similar tasks.

Serotonin: Serotonin is another neurotransmitter that influences mood, emotions, and social behaviors. Higher levels of serotonin have been linked to more positive emotions and increased feelings of self-worth, which can contribute to the development of self-efficacy.

Scales

General Self-Efficacy Scale (GSE):

The General Self-Efficacy Scale, developed by Ralf Schwarzer and Matthias Jerusalem, is a widely used measure of overall self-efficacy beliefs. It consists of 10 items, and respondents rate their agreement with statements on a Likert scale, typically ranging from 1 (not at all true) to 4 (exactly true). Example items include "I can always manage to solve difficult problems if I try hard enough" and "I can usually handle whatever comes my way."

Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale was developed by Albert Bandura, assesses self-efficacy beliefs in specific domains, such as academic tasks, sports, or public speaking. The scale typically consists of items specific to the domain being measured. Participants rate their confidence levels in performing various tasks within that domain.

Academic Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale focuses specifically on academic-related tasks and measures a student's confidence in their ability to excel in academic activities such as studying, test-taking, and completing assignments.

Occupational Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale assesses self-efficacy beliefs related to one's work or profession. It measures confidence in performing job-related tasks, handling workplace challenges, and achieving success in the chosen career.

Social Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale evaluates a person's confidence in social interactions and communication. It may include items related to initiating conversations, making friends, or speaking in public.

Parental Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale assesses parents' beliefs in their abilities to effectively fulfill their parental roles, including tasks like discipline, nurturing, and supporting their children.

Exercise Self-Efficacy Scale:

This scale measures an individual's confidence in their ability to engage in regular exercise and maintain a physically active lifestyle.

HOPE

Hope means *to want something to happen or to be true* (**desire for future**)

It is the belief that your future will be better than the present and that you have the ability to make it happen. Hope consists of both cognitive elements and affective elements. Hope helps us remain committed to our goals and motivated to take action towards achieving. Hope gives people a reason to continue fighting and believing that their current circumstances will improve, despite the unpredictable nature of human existence.

According to Charles Snyder,

“A rainbow is a prism that sends shards of multicolored light in various directions. It lifts our spirits and makes us think of what is possible. Hope is the same – a personal rainbow of the mind”

According to Snyder’s Hope Theory, hope comprised of three distinct but related components:

1. **Goals Thinking** – the clear conceptualization of valuable goals.
2. **Pathways Thinking** – the capacity to develop specific strategies to reach those goals.
3. **Agency Thinking** – the ability to initiate and sustain the motivation for using those strategies.

Example:

Maria just found out she has diabetes. While the news is shocking but she’s determined to stay hopeful.

Goal: Jenny makes a goal to get as healthy as possible.

Pathways: Jenny develops several different strategies to meet her goal of getting healthy. She develops a healthy eating plan, a daily exercise regimen, and decides to learn all she can about diabetes.

Agency: She takes inventory of her motivation. She knows her goal is achievable if she perseveres. She knows she wants to get well for her loved ones and herself.

Psychological benefits of Hope

High-hope people tend to have higher levels of overall well-being.

- more positive emotions
- stronger sense of purpose and meaning
- lower levels of depression
- less loneliness

Physical benefits of Hope

According to the findings, high-hope people experienced the following:

- better physical health
- fewer number of chronic illnesses
- lower risk of cancer
- fewer sleep problems

Childhood antecedent of hope

- Individuals' hopeful thinking develops and becomes increasingly complex at each developmental period: preschool, childhood, and adolescence (Snyder, 2000).
- Hope is initially influenced by the home environment and then later reinforced through social and other learning experiences.
- Strong parenting attachment is crucial for high hope development.
- There is no hereditary component involved.
- Childhood traumas lessen hope.

Neurobiology of Hope

Your brain pumps chemicals when experiencing the sensation of hope. These chemicals can block pain and accelerate healing. Hope, which involves belief and expectation, causes the brain to release neurochemicals called endorphins and enkephalins which actually mimic the effects of morphine.

Flow Theory

Flow theory, also known as the flow state or optimal experience, is a concept in positive psychology that was developed by psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi in the 1970s. The theory explores the psychological state that people experience when they are fully immersed and engaged in an activity, often resulting in a deep sense of satisfaction and enjoyment. This state of flow is characterized by a perfect balance between the challenge level of the task and the individual's skill level.

In positive psychology, a **flow state**, also known as being in the zone, is the mental state in which a person performing some activity is fully immersed in a feeling of energized focus, full involvement, and enjoyment in the process of the activity. In essence, flow is characterized by the complete absorption in what one does, and a resulting transformation in one's sense of time. Flow is the melting together of action and consciousness; the state of finding a balance between a skill and how challenging that task is. It requires a high level of concentration; however, it should be effortless. Flow is used as a coping skill for stress and anxiety when productively pursuing a form of leisure that matches one's skill set.

Example:

Think about a time when you were playing your favorite video game. You were so focused on the game that you lost track of time. You were completely immersed, and it felt like the controller was an extension of your hands. Challenges in the game matched your skills perfectly, making it exciting but not too hard. Your attention was fixed, and you forgot about everything else around you. Hours felt like minutes, and you felt a sense of accomplishment

and joy, simply from playing the game. That's what being in a flow state feels like being so engaged and happy in what you're doing that everything else fades away.

Characteristics

The flow state can be entered while performing any activity, although it is more likely to occur when the task or activity is wholeheartedly engaged for intrinsic purposes. Passive activities such as taking a bath or even watching TV, usually do not elicit a flow experience because active engagement is prerequisite to entering the flow state. While the activities that induce flow vary and may perhaps be multifaceted, Csikszentmihalyi asserts that the experience of flow is similar whatever the activity.

Flow theory postulates that three conditions must be met to achieve flow:

1. The activity must have clear goals and progress. This establishes structure and direction.
2. The task must provide clear and immediate feedback. This helps to negotiate any changing demands and allows adjusting performance to maintain the flow state.
3. Good balance is required between the perceived challenges of the task and one's perceived skills. Confidence in the ability to complete the task is required.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oGJi7i1Ife0>

To get more understanding of this topic kindly watch this video.

Dynamics of flow

Here are some dynamics of flow in positive psychology:

Clear Goals and Feedback: Flow tends to occur when the individual has a clear goal or objective for the task at hand. This provides a sense of direction and purpose. Immediate and clear feedback is also essential, as it helps the individual adjust their actions to stay aligned with their goals.

Balanced Challenge and Skill Level: Flow is most likely to occur when the level of challenge presented by the activity is in balance with the individual's skill level. If the challenge is too easy, it can lead to boredom, and if it's too difficult, it can cause anxiety. Achieving flow requires finding the "sweet spot" where the challenge and skill level are well-matched.

Focused Attention: During a state of flow, individuals are completely absorbed in the activity, leading to focused attention. This intense concentration often results in a feeling of time distortion, where hours can feel like minutes.

Loss of Self-Consciousness: When in flow, individuals tend to lose self-awareness and self-consciousness. They become so engrossed in the task that their worries and concerns fade away, leading to a sense of freedom from self-judgment.

Intrinsic Motivation: Flow is typically associated with activities that are intrinsically motivating – activities that individuals engage in because they find them inherently enjoyable and fulfilling, rather than for external rewards.

Feeling of Control: In the state of flow, individuals feel a sense of control over their actions and the outcomes of the task. This sense of control contributes to a feeling of confidence and competence.

Transformation of Experience: Engaging in a flow-inducing activity can transform an ordinary experience into an extraordinary one. Everyday activities become more meaningful, and the individual's overall well-being can be enhanced.

Absorption and Immersion: Flow is characterized by a deep sense of absorption and immersion in the task. The individual's attention is fully focused on the task at hand, reducing distractions and allowing for a more complete engagement.

Positive Emotions: Flow experiences are often accompanied by positive emotions such as joy, satisfaction, and a sense of accomplishment. These emotions contribute to the overall positive impact of the flow state on psychological well-being.

Creativity and Productivity: Flow has been linked to enhanced creativity and productivity. When individuals are fully immersed in a task, they can often produce higher-quality work and come up with novel solutions to challenges.

Fostering flow:

Fostering a state of flow involves creating an environment and mindset that promotes optimal experiences of engagement, focus, and enjoyment. Fostering flow involves creating conditions that facilitate a deep and immersive engagement with tasks, leading to a state of optimal experience and performance. To cultivate flow, it's important to choose activities that challenge your skills without overwhelming you. This balance between challenge and skill sparks interest and concentration. Setting clear goals for each task provides direction, while immediate feedback helps you make adjustments to stay on track and maintain focus.

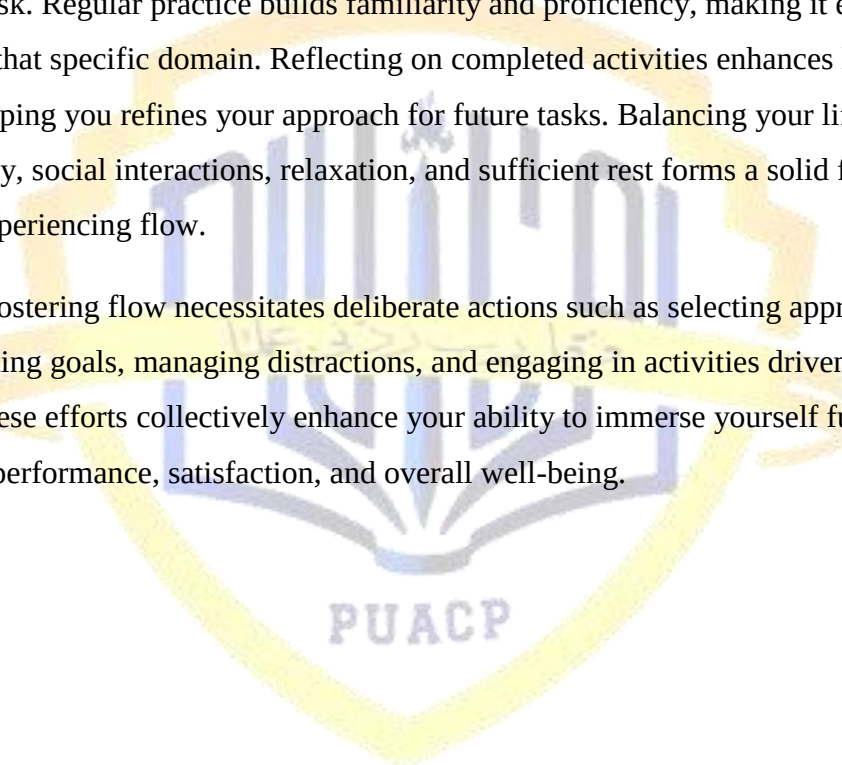
Minimizing distractions by creating a focused environment supports sustained attention and prevents interruptions. Developing expertise through continuous skill improvement enables you to take on more complex challenges and increases the likelihood of achieving flow.

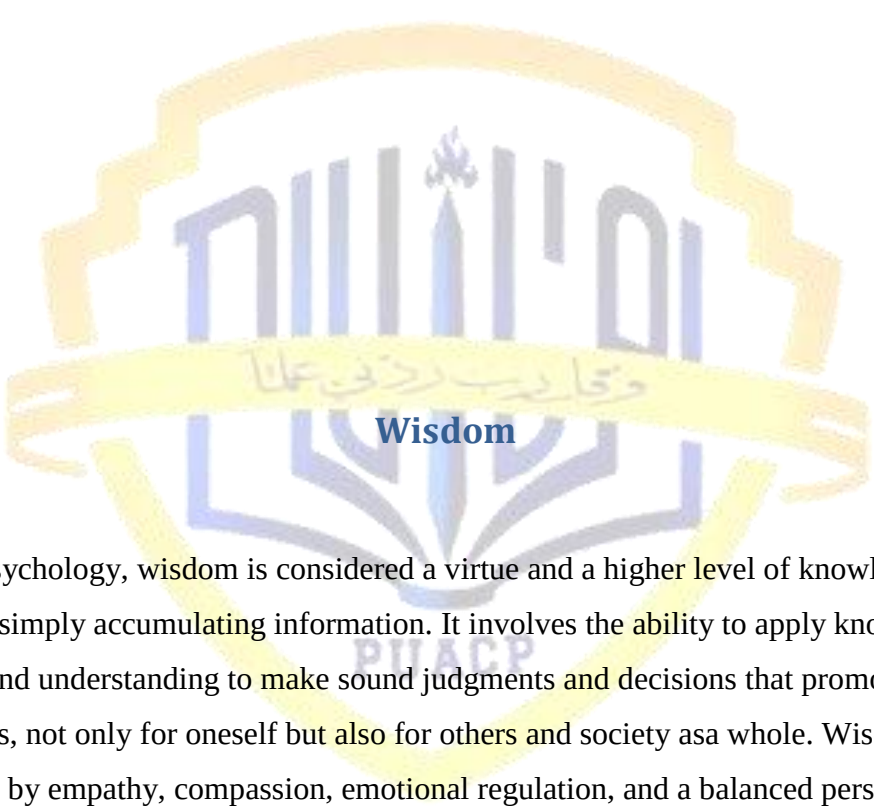
Mindfulness techniques help individual keep your attention in the present moment, preventing thoughts from disrupting your focus.

Creating a workspace that suits your needs encourages a perfect transition into flow. Managing any anxiety related to tasks involves breaking them down into manageable steps, boosting your confidence and reducing potential stressors.

Allocating dedicated time for focused work eliminates time pressures and allows for a deep dive into the task. Regular practice builds familiarity and proficiency, making it easier to enter a flow state in that specific domain. Reflecting on completed activities enhances learning and growth that helping you refines your approach for future tasks. Balancing your lifestyle with physical activity, social interactions, relaxation, and sufficient rest forms a solid foundation for consistently experiencing flow.

In **summary**, fostering flow necessitates deliberate actions such as selecting appropriate challenges, setting goals, managing distractions, and engaging in activities driven by intrinsic motivation. These efforts collectively enhance your ability to immerse yourself fully in tasks, boosting your performance, satisfaction, and overall well-being.





Wisdom

Definition:

In positive psychology, wisdom is considered a virtue and a higher level of knowledge that goes beyond simply accumulating information. It involves the ability to apply knowledge, experience, and understanding to make sound judgments and decisions that promote well-being and happiness, not only for oneself but also for others and society as a whole. Wisdom is characterized by empathy, compassion, emotional regulation, and a balanced perspective on life's challenges. It is often associated with a deeper sense of meaning, purpose, and fulfillment.

Explicit Theory of Wisdom:

The explicit theory of wisdom is based on formal definitions and frameworks that attempt to describe and explain what wisdom is and how it operates. Scholars and researchers often develop explicit models of wisdom to study and analyze its characteristics. These models can include specific components, attributes, or principles that are considered essential for wisdom.

For example, some explicit theories of wisdom propose that wisdom involves the ability to make sound judgments, considering the long-term consequences of actions, displaying

empathy and compassion, recognizing multiple perspectives, and integrating emotional intelligence with rational thinking.

Psychologists and philosophers have also explored various dimensions of wisdom, such as cognitive wisdom (intellectual understanding), reflective wisdom (self-awareness and self-insight), affective wisdom (emotional regulation), and pro social wisdom (concern for the well-being of others).

The explicit theory of wisdom plays a crucial role in guiding research, education, and interventions aimed at fostering wisdom in individuals and societies. It allows for the development of assessments to measure wisdom and serves as a basis for developing strategies to enhance wisdom-related skills and attitudes.

Implicit Theory of Wisdom:

The implicit theory of wisdom is more intuitive and subjective. It represents an individual's unspoken beliefs, ideas, and notions about wisdom, which may not be clearly articulated but influence their actions and judgments in life situations.

With implicit theories, we mean the beliefs or mental representations that people have about wisdom and the characteristics of wise persons. In studies on implicit beliefs about wisdom and wise persons, one finds quite a high degree of overlap in the core aspects of wisdom, even though authors have focused on slightly different aspects and named their components differently. All conceptions include cognitive as well as social, motivational, and emotional components.

The cognitive components usually include strong intellectual abilities, rich knowledge and experience in matters of the human condition, and an ability to apply one's theoretical knowledge practically. A second basic component refers to reflective judgment that is based on knowledge about the world and the self, an openness for new experiences, and the ability to learn from mistakes. Socio emotional components generally include good social skills, such as sensitivity and concern for others and the ability to give good advice. A fourth motivational component refers to the good intentions that usually are associated with wisdom. That is, wisdom aims at solutions that optimize the benefit of others and oneself.

These implicit theories of wisdom can vary significantly among different cultures, age groups, and social backgrounds. They are often shaped by personal experiences, upbringing, exposure to role models, and the cultural context in which a person is embedded. For instance, in some

cultures, wisdom might be associated with age and life experience, while in others, it could be linked to a spiritual or philosophical understanding. Similarly, people might associate wisdom with humility, patience, or the ability to find solutions to complex problems.

Implicit theories can sometimes be in contrast to explicit theories of wisdom. While explicit theories provide formal definitions, implicit beliefs may be more flexible and adaptable, allowing individuals to navigate complex and uncertain situations with a deeper understanding of what is wise in a given context.

Difference between implicit and explicit theories of wisdom:

The implicit theory of wisdom refers to an individual's unconscious beliefs and assumptions about what wisdom is and how it develops. These beliefs often shape their behaviors and decisions.

On the other hand, the explicit theory of wisdom involves consciously held beliefs about wisdom and its characteristics. This theory is more deliberate and can be articulated by individuals.

Both implicit and explicit theories influence how people perceive and pursue wisdom, impacting their personal growth and decision-making processes.

In summary, explicit theories of wisdom offer a structured and formal understanding of wisdom, while implicit theories are subjective, personal beliefs that can vary widely among individuals and cultures. Both aspects contribute to our collective understanding of wisdom and influence how individuals perceive, aspire to, and apply wisdom in their lives.

Relationship between wisdom and intelligence

The relationship between wisdom and intelligence is complex, as both concepts are distinct but can also intersect in certain ways. Here are some key points to understand their relationship:

Definitions:

Intelligence refers to the ability to learn, reason, and solve problems effectively. It is often measured through standardized tests, such as IQ tests, and is associated with cognitive abilities and academic performance.

Wisdom, on the other hand, is a broader and more multifaceted concept. It involves not only cognitive abilities but also emotional intelligence, empathy, compassion, practical judgment, and a deep understanding of human nature and life's complexities.

Wisdom goes beyond mere intelligence and encompasses the application of knowledge to make morally sound and balanced decisions.

1. Overlap and Distinctions: While wisdom and intelligence can overlap in some aspects, they are not synonymous. Some wise individuals may be highly intelligent, but not all intelligent individuals exhibit wisdom. Intelligence may facilitate the acquisition and processing of knowledge, but wisdom requires an additional level of insight, experience, and understanding of the human condition.

2. Development: Intelligence is often seen as more malleable and subject to improvement through education and learning. It can be developed and enhanced over time, especially during early developmental stages. Wisdom, on the other hand, is considered to be influenced by both nature and nurture. While some aspects of wisdom might be innate, such as personality traits that contribute to it, wisdom also requires life experiences, reflection, and the integration of knowledge and emotions over time. Thus, wisdom tends to be associated with older age and accumulated life experiences.

3. Application: Intelligence is often used to solve specific problems, excel in academic settings, or master certain skills. It is valuable in various professional and technical fields. Wisdom, however, is more oriented towards making sound and compassionate judgments in complex life situations, considering the long-term consequences of actions, and understanding the broader ethical implications of one's choices. It is often related to decision-making in personal, social, and moral contexts.

In conclusion, while wisdom and intelligence share some common elements related to cognitive abilities, they are distinct concepts. Wisdom involves a deeper understanding of human behavior, emotions, and ethics, whereas intelligence primarily relates to cognitive prowess and problem-solving abilities. While intelligence can be measured and improved through education, wisdom is a more complex construct that develops through experience, reflection, and emotional intelligence

Courage

Definition

Courage is a measure of a person's ability to cope with physical or psychological pain and challenges. The term is sometimes used to refer to people who appear to be fearless, but is generally used when people are able to do something frightening even if they feel afraid. People are sometimes described as courageous, and a person's individual courage can affect his or her personality. People who measure high on anxiety scales often exhibit less courage than people with low measures of anxiety. Because anxiety is relatively stable across a person's life span, courage can also appear relatively stable. However, anxious people can behave in courageous ways, especially when they learn to cope with their anxiety and confront frightening obstacles. The field of positive psychology, which is dedicated to building upon people's strengths rather than treating their weaknesses, often focuses on helping people develop courage. One of the most common acts of courage we see is when someone stands up for what they believe or their core values. You've most likely seen this demonstrated in the classroom, your workplace, in your community, and even around the globe.

Why is courage important?

Courage gives you the ability to put aside your fear of failure and take the first steps. Courage helps you overcome the fear of rejection and engage your stakeholders. Courage allows you to attempt things that you have not tried before, despite your fear of looking foolish.

Physical Courage:

Physical courage is bravery in the face of physical pain, hardship, even death, or threat of death. Physical courage is the type most people think of first, the one that allows us to risk discomfort, injury, pain or even death—running into burning buildings as a firefighter, facing an enemy on the battlefield, undergoing chemotherapy, climbing a mountain, protecting a child from a dangerous animal.

Moral Courage

Moral courage is the ability to stand up for and practice that which one considers ethical, moral behavior when faced with a dilemma, even if it means going against countervailing pressure to do. An example of moral courage can include: Speaking out against injustices even when no one else does. Taking action when you know it will cost you personally can help others. Standing up for your beliefs in the face of criticism from peers, family, and friends. Moral courage helps us address ethical issues and take action when doing the right thing is not easy. Moral courage involves the willingness to speak out and do what is right in the face of forces that would lead us to act in some other way. Using moral courage appropriately means learning to express oneself in an honest and direct manner at the right place and time.

Vital Courage:

Vital courage, a term pioneered by Finfgeld (1995), is defined as the persistence through a personal struggle, disease, or disability even when the outcome is uncertain.

An example of vital courage is that shown by the person persevering with treatment for cancer when the outcome may be uncertain.

Psychological courage:

The courage to face addictions, phobias, and obsessions, and to avoid self deception and admit mistakes. Psychological courage include saving another's or one's own life against a meaningful threat; coping with a painful, debilitating, or terminal illness; overcoming a destructive habit; and voicing an unpopular opinion. To achieve this, positive psychologists have aligned the idea of psychological courage with four strengths: integrity (acting with authenticity), bravery (expressing moral courage in the face of opposition), persistence and vitality (being wholehearted in your approach to life).

Fear and Courage:

Courage and fear are often viewed as opposite experiences. However, they are actually intrinsically related. How? Fear is a common and natural feeling. Courage is derived from being able to overcome those feelings. Courageous people feel fear, but they are able to manage and overcome their fear so that it does not stop them from moving through it. Many find that their fear fuels their ambition, often using it to navigate whatever they are facing and find a way to take the appropriate actions to achieve their goal.

